Not the Phil Donahue Show

By Kelly Cherry

This is not the Phil Donahue show; this is my life. So why is my daughter, who is 20 years old and, to me, so heartbreakingly beautiful that I think that for the sake of the health of the entire world and probably universe she shouldn't be allowed out of the house without a cardiologist at her side, why is my daughter standing in my doorway telling me she's a lesbian?

INTRODUCTION

The Mother / Daughter relationship is one of the most complex relationships that exists in our society. Mothers want things for their daughters: weddings and grandchildren and lives that other people won't judge. Mothers want their daughters to go to college and have careers and be proud of who they are. All of these desires become threatened when a daughter confides in her mother that she is gay. Not the Phil Donahue Show by Kelly Cherry

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If I say it's a phase, that she'll outgrow it, she'll peel herself from the wall like wallpaper and exit, perhaps permanently,

If I say honey, that's great, nonchalant and accepting as history, I could be consigning her to a life that I'm not sure she really wants—maybe she's just testing me. Maybe this *is* just a phase.

It is five o'clock. It's already been a long day, which I have spent as I spend most of my days—nursing patients to whom I have let myself get too close. But I'm always home from my shift at the hospital by four-thirty, while Ian stays late after school to devise lesson plans, tutor the sluggardly, confer with parents.

Now the front door swings open and it's Ian. Isabel has not moved from her post in the doorway between us.

"Hi, Shel," Ian says to me. "Hi, Belle," he says to my daughter. "Nice to see you."

He wants so much for her to let him enter her life. He has no children of his own—he wants to be, if

not a second father, at least a good friend.

"Isabel has an announcement," I say

"I'm in love," I hear her say behind my back.

"Hey, that's great," Ian responds and I realize how unfair we have been to him, we have set him up for this.

"With a woman," she says.

Girl, I want to correct her. With a *girl.*

"Oh," Ian says. "Well, why isn't she here? When do we get to meet her?"

And I remember: this is why I married him. Because he puts people ahead of his expectations for them. Because he doesn't create a crisis where there isn't one.

But this is a crisis. If she were *his* daughter, he'd realize that.

As soon as Ian suggested we meet, Isabel raced out of the house and brought her back for supper.

Judy is not what I expected. For one thing, she's pretty— almost as pretty as my daughter. It is easy to

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see why Isabel has fallen in love with her; in fact, I don't see how anyone could *not* fall in love with either of them—so why shouldn't they fall in love with each other?

"They are children," I say to Ian in the kitchen, after they have vanished into the night.

"Isabel's almost 21," he says. "You've got to start getting used to the idea that she's grown up. She has her own life to live."

"That's easy for you to say."

He slams the silverware drawer shut. "No, it isn't, Shelley. As a matter of fact, it's very hard for me to say, because I know you're upset and you're going to take it out on me. It would be much easier for me not to say anything, but someone has to keep you from making a big mistake here."

"Call Nelson. Maybe *he* can keep you from going off the deep end."

I look at Ian; I pick up the phone; I dial. It rings. "Nel?" I say. "I need to talk to you. Can you meet me at

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Porta Bella?"

"In 20 minutes," he says. "Listen, I know what it's about. Everything's going to be all right."

"She told you first?" I ask. I can't help it, I'm hurt.

"It's hard on her, our divorce," he says. "I'm happy things have worked out for you with Ian, but you must realize she senses a barrier there now. There's not the same unimpeded access to you that she had."

"Do you think she's doing this just to get back at me? Will she grow out of it?"

"I think it's the real thing, Shelley," he says. He smiles. "I think she's in love . . . She's still our little girl."

"She always will be," I agree. "And she's *free to be herself*. It's just that, well, weren't you counting on grandchildren someday?"

"I wouldn't rule out the possibility yet," he says. "A lot of lesbians have children, one way or another. I think she wants to have children someday."

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The next day . . . . . Gloved and gowned, I duck into Reed's room.

Reed has AIDS. He has been here before, during two other episodes of acute infection. This time he has pneumonia. This time, when he leaves here, he will go to a nursing home to die.

Reed lies there on his back, with his eyes shut, as if drifting farther and farther from shore.

"Reed," I say to call him back.

I believe the dementia that occurs in 80 percent of AIDS patients has begun to manifest itself, but it's hard to say. I don't know what Reed was like before he became an AIDS patient.

I pull up a chair and sit beside him. The skinnier he gets, the more room his eyes take up in his face. He winks at me.

"Hello, Shelley," he says.

"I thought for a minute you'd forgotten me."

"I still have my *mind*, Shelley, It's just my body that's going."

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I don't contradict him. He knows everything there is to know at this point about his disease. He knows more about it than I do—like many AIDS victims, he has read the research, questioned the doctors, exchanged information. At the limits of knowledge, the issue becomes belief, and I figure he has a right to choose his beliefs. Reed believes he will lick his illness.

I look at the *body that's going:* He has lost more weight since his last hospitalization, despite a rigorous fitness plan. His cheekbones are as pointy as elbows. His brown eyes have lost some of their laughter. When I pick up his hand to hold it, it doesn't squeeze back. There are sores on his arms—the giveaway lesions of Karposi's Sarcoma. K. S. , we say around here. I take his pulse, the wrist between my fingers and thumb not much bigger than a sugar tube.

"Reed," I ask him, "are you sorry you're gay?" I almost say *were. As in were gay. Or sorry you were gay.*

"Because of this?"

"No. Just—if there were no such thing as AIDS,

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if nobody ever died from it, would you be glad to be gay?"

"How can I answer that? How can I pretend Eddie never died?"

Eddie was his lover; he died of AIDS two years ago, in California. Reed came back home, but his parents, small dairy farmers in northern Wisconsin, have been unable, or perhaps unwilling, to look after him.

Tears leap to his eyes, those tears, and others to mine. "Why are you interrogating me about my feelings like this? This is not the Phil Donahue show! This is my life!"

I understand that. All over America, people are struggling to prove to themselves that their lives are more than television, that their lives are real, the real thing.

I think of all the things he might have said, the true profanity of his condition, and it seems to me that no words could ever be as shocking as "Phil" and "Donahue" and "Show," words that have brought America

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into this hospital room

I don't care what kind of life Isabel leads, so long as she gets to lead one.

I think of my beautiful daughter, her grumpy spirit caged by the circumstances of her own sexuality and her mother's, and of how it will one day—soon, I think—be freed, *free to be itself*.

Not that I wouldn't prefer things to be otherwise; not that I am exactly happy about my daughter's choice. I wouldn't go so far as that—not yet. I love her too much not to know that the day will come when I will feel however I must feel in order to keep her in my life.

Sometimes I think of the whole world as a kind of hospital, the earth itself as a patient.

There are days, now, when so much seems to be slipping away. Even the things one tends not to think of, like the walnuts. The walnuts are slipping away, going off to be stockpiled by squirrels. The green of summer is slipping away, hiding its light under a bush or a bushel of

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autumn leaves. There are dreams that slip away in the middle of the night, losing themselves forever in some dark corner of the subconscious. There are stars that are disappearing even as we look at them. There are mothers and fathers and children, all of them slipping away like the fish in the pond, going down deeper for winter. And you reach out to hold on to your child, and she is slipping away, going off into some life that is not your life, and you are afraid to see her go because you know, you know how far it is possible to go, how far it is possible for things to slip away.

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